

price. Our government's partly to blame, of course, but it's not like manufacturers aren't making a bucketload as well. And what happens if the device fails? Of course we don't care, our eyes are too blinded by the bling and the call of the Apple sirens.

It isn't just popular consumer products that are affected, have you thought about your precious PC? The 660Ti for example, NVIDIA's latest offering, sells for only \$300 abroad (₹16,000), but the very same product is available, officially, for over ₹25,000!

Promised land in the clouds

The world is moving to the clouds. That is what everyone wants you to believe. From OSes to your pirated music, it's all there, somewhere. How do you get to it? Well, let's not worry about that right now, shall we? Let's sell cloud this and cloud that, and make full use of the buzzword. Makes total sense as a product, but in the US, not for most of us.

Newfangled communication

You see more and more people around you flaunting the latest mobiles. They're not shy to tell you exactly what the salesman did either. "This is the latest model, it has 3G and Near-Field-Communication – you know, to make mobile payments with". At this point we usually ask them to name one place where they've paid a bill by only waving their mobile, and the silence is deafening. If not, we get some chatter about 'future-proofing', this from a person that still prefers to invest in gold to keep in the *tijori*. 3G is another lie if every there was one. Some operators, and some metros, sure, it's a decent experience that's pretty expensive. Most of India though, you'd be lucky to get a signal, but every

mobile shop you come across seems to be pushing the latest handsets.

Finding your way

GPS is pretty much standard for most people in developed countries. It makes absolute sense, too. Apart from massaging the male ego by never having to ask for directions, it also carries other awesome perks – like a sexy female voice telling you where to turn. Apart from that, it's usually just viewing a map, much like you can do with Google maps. With streets changing names often, the lack of street signs, and smaller roads not being mapped, GPS isn't all that it's cracked up to be. Where it does make sense is in the US, where you get live traffic updates, and can calculate alternate routes quickly. Heck even Google maps gives you street view for the west, here you only look at low res satellite images and hope for the best.

US not us

There is a very interesting parallel that someone cooked up the other day. This fascination of consuming for the sake of it, is not new. It is, in fact, really old. Ever since we fell behind the frontrunners of the global ecosystem, the few of us who had enough resources have been trying to enjoy the comforts of our foreign counterparts. Under the British rule, the Indian princes were exclusively exposed to western studies, philosophies, and even entertainment. While arguments for the issue can be made, our thinking is that this was essentially destructive as far as national ties are concerned. They embraced foreign ideals, when they were supposed to integrate with the Indian masses one day. While this latest incarna-

THE CORPORATE VIEWPOINT

Companies might seem to work on 'we-love-money' and 'no-other-darn-shall-be-given' approach. To be fair, it's not all their fault. For starters, the money spent on developing the tech that they sell is of the order of crazy. A genuinely multi-national company can expect to spend anywhere between 1 to 3 billion dollars (INR 1,65,00,00,00,000 - if it helps) in research and development of its products. While the sum might be lower for software and service providers, but the idea still holds. Such sums of money are spent to develop technology to keep pace with the best resources in the world. It's not their fault if everybody is not compliant with those standards. If they were to build new products from the ground up for each new market then this cost instantly doubles, at the very least. And the prohibitive taxes for imports existent in most of the concerned countries means that the big corps are almost powerless when it comes to either the tech, or the pricing issue. Sure, you could ask them to bite the bullet for either (or for both), but as much as it pales in comparison to their otherworldly incomes, 3 billion dollars is not pocket change by anybody's standards. "They're just doing what they can."

tion of the trend isn't of similarly radical implications, the irony is just too strong to miss. So why does this happen? Young adults here, especially the ones with more moolah to blow, want to show-off to their mates here (because they don't have it), and feel or appear at par when they make mates there (because they have them too). Whatever it is, it's certainly not "Buying Smart!" Watch out for next month's issue, which will help you do just that, and also help you save a ton of cash. We just hope you won't go off and blow all your savings on silly things like these! 

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